

Building the Globe

IN 1597, THE THEATRE was forced to close. It had been built on rented land, and the Burbages' agreement with the landowner had come to an end. The landowner refused to renew the lease because he hoped to keep the playhouse for himself and reuse its valuable oak timbers. Desperate to find a home for their players, the brothers came up with a plan. During the Christmas holidays of 1598, they hired workmen to pull the Theatre down. They took the oak timbers by boat across the river to Bankside, where they used them to build a new playhouse. They decided to call it the Globe.



Round
pegs and
joints



Square pegs
and joints

KNOCK DOWN

The wooden joints of the Theatre were attached with pegs, which meant that the Burbages and their helpers could knock them apart using hammers. The undamaged timbers were then reassembled on the new site to make the frame of the Globe.

WALL STORY

After making the frame, the builders installed wall panels. Timber-framed buildings sometimes had walls made from wattle (woven mats of hazel stems) covered with daub (a mixture of clay, lime, straw, horsehair, and dung). Walls were also made using thin strips of wood called lath, plastered with lime, horsehair, and sand.



SOMETHING OLD, SOMETHING NEW

Inside the Globe, skilled carpenters used special tools to carve, drill, and chisel decorative features. The interior was colorful, with the stage columns painted to look like marble. The Burbages made sure that their new playhouse was an improvement on the old one.



Auger for
boring holes
in wood

Hammer

Awls for
making
small holes

Billhook for
pruning and
lopping

Hand
saw

Chisel

Broad
ax



The Globe's stage, as imagined by George Cruikshank in 1863, with Victorian-style scenery and curtains



Gallery
seats

Gentlemen's
room for wealthy
audience members

Hell (space beneath the stage)